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STARTUP TIMES

A QUARTERLY E-MAGAZINE FROM KERALA STARTUP MISSION

Kerala has around 6200+ startups working in various sectors spread across its 14 districts. Our startups work in wide range of sectors including Artificial Intelligence, Hardware, Healthcare, Fin tech, Bio Technology etc.



WORLD CLASS INFRASTRUCTURE TO ACCELERATE YOUR GROWTH

10 Lakh Sq. ft across the
state to handhold the
startups in their
entrepreneurial journey

6200+
STARTUPS

04
ACCELERATORS

63
INCUBATORS

502
MINI INCUBATORS

5800CR
VC & ANGEL FUNDING

30 CR
INNOVATION GRANT

60K
EMPLOYMENT GENERATED

40000+
ASPIRING ENTREPRENEURS

101 CR
FUND OF FUND



"BEING AN ENTREPRENEUR REQUIRES YOU TO SURF THROUGH DIFFERENT TURFS IN ONE GO. THIS NEEDS PASSION AND LOVE FOR WHAT YOU ARE DOING."

AMAN GUPTA
CO-FOUNDER & CMO,
BOAT

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Making Waves

As Ryng gained momentum, more clients began trying out the newcomer product, placing their trust and customer communication in its hands. The platform quickly expanded into new verticals, including banking and fintech, attracting notable clients like HDFC Securities, AngelOne, and ICICI Securities. Ryng also made significant strides in the insurance sector with Kotak Life Insurance and TVS Credit, while partnerships with Dvara and Tala further solidified its position in fintech. YULU's adoption of Ryng marked its entry into the growing e-mobility market, showcasing the product's versatility across industries.

Building Trust, One Client at a Time

The early trust placed in Ryng by industry leaders set the stage for its success. Word began to spread, and despite having no major marketing campaigns or presence at big conferences, Ryng garnered strong traction through word of mouth and key partnerships. Instead of rushing for more clients, the team focused on collaborating with the best in each industry, refining Ryng to meet their needs before expanding further. This patient, relationship-driven approach helped Ryng become a go-to solution for some of India's top enterprises, competing against global giants by offering intelligent, tailored communication tools. Codeof duty's focus on long-term client relationships, rather than heavy marketing, has been key to its growth and recognition.

A Special Win

Beyond Ryng, the team is always working on groundbreaking, innovative projects, and one such effort led to a major achievement. In 2019, the team struck gold by winning Intel's national-level AI hackathon, HackFury2, emerging victorious from 5,000 participants. Their winning project was a hand-gesture recognition solution using a wristband, showcasing their technical prowess and innovative mindset. This spirit of exploration is core to the company, even though Ryng itself has stayed away from high-profile competitions.

Bold New Steps

The team at Codeof duty is grateful for having a great team to build Ryng together and for the strong support from Kerala Startup Mission throughout their journey. What began as a small team from Kerala is now managing customer communications for Fortune 500 companies, proving that world-class products can emerge from focused innovation. Currently, the team is working on two fronts—opening up Ryng to more clients and adding major updates to further improve communications. They are also diving deep into the new age of LLMs to improve customer experience while making them truly accessible to companies of all sizes.

STARTUP OF THE MONTH

CODEOFDUTY:

Building Intelligence into Customer Communications with Ryng

In 2018, Sanju Mathew, Benjamin, and a group of their friends launched Codeofduty with a bold vision: to bring intelligence to customer communications. This wasn't just about entering an established market dominated by 20-year-old giants or navigating a space cluttered with newcomers; it was about redefining how businesses connect with their customers.



Road to Ryng

The customer communication space, once dominated by hardware-heavy systems requiring significant capital investment, saw a shift around 2010 when cloud telephony reduced CAPEX and enabled more scalable solutions. By 2018, many CRMs offered basic calling and SMS, but most lacked intelligence and effective engagement strategies, leaving businesses struggling to reach customers at the right time through the best channels. Spam and poor customer experience further worsened the problem, as platforms failed to provide meaningful, timely engagement. The rise of Truecaller highlighted the ineffectiveness of these systems, prompting Codeofduty to develop a smarter, more intuitive solution: Ryng.

First Win

They built the first version of Ryng, launched an MVP, and quickly secured Myntra and Jabong as their first major clients in the e-commerce sector. Within months, Ryng doubled customer communication rates for these brands and addressed key challenges like redelivering unsuccessful packages. Today, six years later, Ryng continues to serve industry leaders like Myntra, Flipkart, and DHL as long-term clients.

FROM THE DESK

AI: CATALYZING THE EVOLUTION OF KERALA'S STARTUP ECOSYSTEM



Anoop Ambika
CEO
KERALA STARTUP MISSION

I have had the unique opportunity to witness firsthand transformative impact that artificial intelligence (AI) has had on our startup ecosystem. AI is not just a technological advancement; it is a powerful force driving innovation, efficiency, and growth across multiple sectors in Kerala.

Over the past few years, we've seen a significant shift in how startups approach problem-solving, driven largely by AI. Startups that once relied heavily on manual processes and human intuition are now harnessing AI to analyze vast amounts of data, predict market trends, and automate routine tasks. This shift has not only increased productivity but also allowed entrepreneurs to focus on what truly matters, "innovation and creativity".

At KSUM, our mission has always been to create a supportive ecosystem where startups can thrive. We recognized early on that AI would play a crucial role in shaping the future of entrepreneurship in Kerala. That's why we've made it a priority to equip our startups with the knowledge, tools, and resources they need to leverage AI effectively.

One of the most exciting developments we've observed is how AI is democratizing access to various industries. Today, a software engineer



in Kerala can effortlessly design graphics or write articles using AI tools, skills that were once outside their domain. Conversely, individuals with basic computer knowledge can now dive into software development, thanks to AI-driven platforms that simplify coding and development processes. This has opened up new avenues for entrepreneurs, enabling them to explore and innovate across diverse fields.

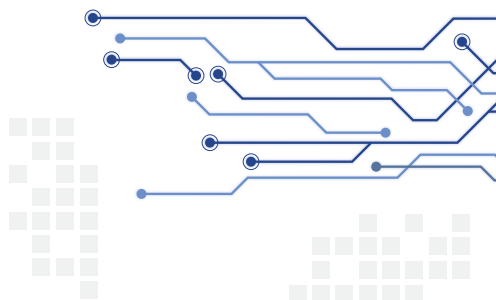
The influence of AI extends beyond just technology startups. We've seen its impact across sectors, from healthcare to education to public services. For instance, AI-powered tools are now being used to design homes, optimize public housing projects, and even automate customer service in small and

medium-sized enterprises (MSMEs). These applications are not just improving efficiency; they are also driving cost savings and enabling startups to scale faster.

One of the challenges we face as we integrate AI into our ecosystem is ensuring that it benefits everyone. The implementation costs, need for technical expertise, and concerns around privacy and security are real issues that we must address. However, we firmly believe that these challenges also present opportunities for Kerala to lead by example. We can show the world that AI doesn't have to lead to job losses; instead, it can create new, higher-value jobs and drive economic growth.

We're not just opening doors to cutting-edge technology for startups, we're also making sure they know how to harness AI in a way that's both ethical and responsible. By keeping our startups informed and equipped with the latest tools, we're giving them the confidence to thrive in this fast-evolving tech landscape.

Looking ahead, I'm genuinely excited about the potential of AI within Kerala's startup ecosystem. We're already witnessing the early stages of an AI-driven transformation, and I'm confident that Kerala has what it takes to become a leader in this space. With the right support and a clear vision, I believe our startups are poised to not just keep up with, but actually lead, the next wave of technological innovation.



From Spark to Structure:

Transforming Ideas into Viable Concepts

Every successful startup begins with a spark : an initial idea that has the potential to change the world. However, transforming that spark into a viable concept is often the most challenging part of the startup journey. Understanding this crucial transition can make the difference between an idea that fades away and one that becomes a super successful business. Here are some insights from Stories from Life on Getting and Validating an Idea:



Adithya S V

Asst Manager
Kerala Startup Mission

Out of limitations comes creativity

Match your idea with the resources at hand and validate it based on financials and potential expenses. Limitations will continuously push you to identify alternatives, which can sometimes be the best way to connect with people. Abid, CEO of Chillr, shared his experience from working with Chillr, where he initially planned to give away mugs with Chillr logos and QR codes for a surprise prize. However, due to cost, time, and operational challenges, he switched to Dairy Milk chocolates, which had a broader acceptance and emotional connection with people, and it worked amazingly well.

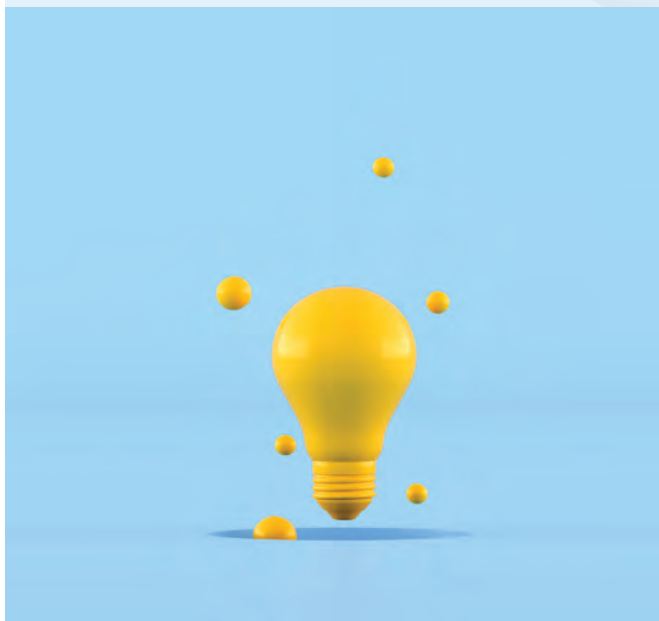
It All Starts With A Spark

Rule No.1: Talk to Users

Talking to users is the golden rule for any startup. Engaging with a wide range of users helps you understand your surroundings and what people truly value. This interaction not only builds your common sense but also enhances your creative thinking. Most importantly, it provides proper validation for your existing ideas, ensuring they meet real needs and have the potential for success.

The Magic of finding the Pathbreaker

The magic lies in the idea or solution nobody has tried yet. By identifying existing limitations or challenges and creating something that addresses those gaps, you can become a true pathbreaker. This innovative approach not only sets you apart but also turns obstacles into opportunities for success. Analyze whether your idea originates from the existing limitations and solve it better than anybody else.



Hacking the Aspirations and Motivations

Aspirations and Motivations involves deeply understanding what drives your target audience. By tapping into their dreams, desires, and motivations, you can create solutions that resonate on a profound level. This approach helps you align your product or service with what truly matters to your users, making your offering more compelling and effective.

Defining Value Propositions : Do Things Don't scale

A value proposition is a statement that communicates why buyers should choose your products or services. In the early stages of your startup journey, defining a compelling value proposition is crucial, and it often involves doing things that don't scale and Do it Yourself. Understanding the space you are in and manually engaging in tasks can make a significant difference. This approach helps in deeply understanding user needs and building a solid foundation. Here are some tactics from successful startups that illustrate this principle:

Do It Yourself

Recruit users manually: Like Stripe, which would take users' laptops and install their software directly. This hands-on approach ensured that early users had a seamless experience and felt valued.

Remember startups are fragile: AirBnB's founders went door to door to take photos of rental properties, which was key in preventing early failure. This personal touch helped build trust and improve the quality of listings.

Make users very happy: Wufoo sent users handwritten cards to show appreciation, creating a strong emotional connection and enhancing user loyalty.

Have insanely great service: Apple made their packaging as impressive as their computers, enhancing the overall user experience and reinforcing their brand's premium value.

Pick a narrow market: Facebook initially launched exclusively at Harvard to build a strong, focused user base, which allowed them to refine their product and create a compelling value proposition before expanding.

Do things yourself: Pebble's founders hand-assembled the first 100 watches due to lack of funds for a factory. This dedication showcased their commitment and helped them understand the production process intimately.

By focusing on these personalized, hands-on approaches, you can define a value proposition that truly resonates with your users and sets your startup on a path to success. Doing things that don't scale may seem counterintuitive, but these efforts can provide invaluable insights and help build a strong, loyal user base.

Refer more: Do things Don't Scale

How Concept Development Framework Works for Startups

A concept development framework can guide startups in refining and organizing their ideas, but it doesn't guarantee success. There are numerous methods and frameworks available, each offering different perspectives and tools. However, it's essential not to rely solely on these frameworks for validating your idea. Instead, use them as a starting point to sense what might actually work for you. Understanding user motivation is crucial: why people take certain actions and what drives their behavior. By gaining this common sense, you can better align your concept with what truly resonates with your target audience.

Here are some frameworks that you can refer to:

SWOT: Evaluates Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats of a business idea or venture. Helps identify internal and external factors that may impact the success of a startup.

Customer Development Process: Four-step framework to discover and validate market need, then build the right product. Emphasizes getting out of the building to talk to potential customers.

AARRR: This is a 5-step model for creating a metrics framework for your business & customers, and how to apply it to your product & marketing efforts.

No idea is perfect from the start. Abid, CEO of Chillr emphasized the importance of continuously seeking feedback and iterating on the concepts. By continuously refining your ideas based on constructive feedback, you can enhance the viability and appeal. This iterative process is vital for startups to adapt and grow in a competitive environment.



MONTH OUTREACH

HUDDLE GLOBAL ROADSHOW

The Huddle Global Roadshow has been an exhilarating journey, and we at KSUM are thrilled with its success! Each stop in Kochi, Trivandrum, and Calicut provided a unique experience, offering a glimpse into the exciting opportunities Huddle Global 2024 will bring. Startup founders shared their insights and experiences, inspiring aspiring entrepreneurs to take bold steps forward. Participants had the chance to connect with industry leaders, network with peers, and showcase their innovative ideas. Huddle Global 2024 is all about turning ideas into reality, making it a must-attend event for anyone eager to grow in the startup ecosystem.



FAB ACADEMY GRADUATION

On August 6th, in Kochi, Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) celebrated the remarkable achievements of the Fab Academy 2024 graduates at the Fab Academy Graduation Ceremony. This prestigious, globally-recognized, six-month intensive course, organized by the Fab Foundation and led by Neil Gershenfeld, Director of MIT's Center for Bits and Atoms, provided participants with hands-on learning experiences in digital fabrication.

Throughout the course, participants engaged in advanced project design and prototyping, with additional expert sessions from distinguished professionals around the world. Graduates of Fab Academy 2024 are now well-equipped to pursue a wide range of career opportunities, including roles in product development and design, positions at Fab Labs worldwide, and research opportunities at renowned institutions like IITs. They also have the chance to collaborate on projects with MIT and the Fab Foundation, and can explore internships and fellowships at Fab Lab Kerala, further enhancing their skills and expanding their professional networks.



Japan Delegation

On August 5, 2024, Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) hosted the Indo-Japanese Academic Exchange Programme, fostering cross-cultural learning and innovation. The event welcomed delegates, including students and teachers from St. Teresa's College, Ernakulam, offering an enriching experience centered on knowledge exchange and technological exploration.

The delegates were introduced to cutting-edge technologies and the vibrant maker culture that drives innovation at KSUM. The program successfully provided the Indo-Japanese participants with a unique perspective on the integration of technology and education, reinforcing the importance of global collaboration in academic and entrepreneurial pursuits.



Conference on Intellectual Property Rights- IPR for Entrepreneurial Growth

The Kerala State Conference on Intellectual Property Rights, focusing on entrepreneurial growth, was held on August 8, 2024, at Kerala Startup Mission, Kochi. Organized by the Consortium of Women Entrepreneurs of India (CWEI), the event aimed to highlight the critical role of intellectual property (IP) in fostering innovation and supporting entrepreneurship. The program commenced at 10:30 AM with an inaugural session featuring a welcome address from the Kerala Startup Mission, followed by key insights from Dr. Shashi Singh, Chairperson of CWEI, and a keynote address by Mr. John Cabeca, United States Intellectual Property Counselor for South Asia.

Throughout the day, various technical sessions were held, beginning with an overview of intellectual property by Dr. R. Bhanumathi, Deputy Controller of Patents & Designs, and discussions on Geographical Indications (GI), trademark, and copyright laws. Industry experts like Ms. Shilpi Jha and Dr. Ambily K.K. provided valuable inputs on the practical aspects of IP rights in different sectors such as marine, MSMEs, and handicrafts. The conference also featured presentations on support services for startups and MSMEs by representatives from SIDBI, Kudumbashree, and the Directorate of Fisheries. The event concluded

with a live design show and certificate distribution, providing participants with actionable knowledge on leveraging IP for business growth.



Web 3- Empowering Kerala with BlockChain

The "Empowering Kerala with Blockchain" conference, put together by Web3Kerala, happened on August 17, 2024, at Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM), Kochi. This one-day event was all about looking into the current scene and future possibilities of Web3 technologies in Kerala. It pulled in a lively crowd of over 250 people, including developers, entrepreneurs, and industry leaders, all excited to dive into the game-changing power of blockchain.

The conference featured a series of expert talks that provided deep insights into the evolving landscape of Web3, delivered by pioneers shaping the future of this technology. Panel discussions followed, where founders and developers shared their experiences and visions, fostering engaging conversations on the possibilities and challenges ahead. Hands-on workshops were also a key highlight, focusing on Layer 2 solutions that drive inno-

vation and adoption in the blockchain space. Attendees had the opportunity to network, collaborate, and discover new market opportunities in Kerala's thriving Web3 economy. The event provided a platform for connecting with skilled developers and potential collaborators, making it a significant step towards advancing the Web3 ecosystem in the region.



Little KITES Interaction & Visit

On 23rd August 2024, selected students from the Little KITES 2022-25 State Level Camp visited Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) in Kochi. The program aimed to inspire young tech enthusiasts by exposing them to the startup ecosystem. The highlight was a presentation by Mr. Anoop Ambika, CEO of KSUM, who shared insights on innovation, entrepreneurship, and the resources available at KSUM. The visit included an interactive session and a tour of the facilities, leaving the students motivated to explore their technological and entrepreneurial potential.

Mani Karthik Workshop- Success Formula for Young Startups

On August 31, 2024, Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) in Kochi hosted a Masterclass with Mani Karthik, a growth hacker known for his success with SaaS brands like Dukaan and HappyFox. The session, aimed at startup founders, covered zero-cost marketing strategies, including the latest SEO techniques, content marketing tools, and proven growth formulas. Participants also received hands-on website health checks and engaged in a live Q&A. The event provided practical insights for founders to boost revenue without significant expenses, emphasizing innovative marketing approaches crucial for startup success.



INNOVATION TOUR

The Innovation Tour is a monthly event for innovators, organized by Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM). It happens on the first Saturday of every month. Here are some highlights from the events held in September and October at the KSUM Kochi Campus. This event acts as a platform for entrepreneurs with innovative business ideas, allowing them to learn about the various programs and resources KSUM offers to support their startups.



AWS STARTUP



Architecture" consultations. The event fostered valuable connections and offered personalized guidance, empowering participants with actionable insights and tools. Attendees left with a deeper understanding of AWS resources, marking the event as a catalyst for innovation in Kerala's startup ecosystem.



AWS Startup Day, themed "Learn & Explore Generative AI with AWS," was held on 25th September 2024 at Kerala Startup Mission, Kalamassery, Kochi. This in-person event aimed to educate startup founders and tech enthusiasts about leveraging generative AI for business scalability. AWS experts conducted sessions on Go-To-Market strategies, fundraising, and technical insights through "Build & Scale with AWS" and exclusive "Know Your



Founders Meet

Kozhikode

The recent Founders Meet series highlighted two impactful gatherings for Kerala's startup ecosystem, with the 23rd edition in Trivandrum followed by the 24th edition at NIT Calicut University. The Trivandrum event brought together an impressive lineup of speakers, including Dr. Lini Basil from Bylin Medtech, Robin Alex Panicker of Finotes, Tina James of Revyrie Global, and Krishnan RV Iyer of Waybeo, who shared valuable insights on scaling strategies, global challenges, and technology-driven growth.

TRIVANDRUM EDITION
FOUNDERS MEET 23.0
03 OCT 2023 | ICF086, Karyavattom, Thiruvananthapuram



Glimpses from the Founders meet Trivandrum edition. The event saw Dr. Lini Basil, Founder & CEO of Bylin Medtech Pvt Ltd, share her company's growth journey and the challenges faced by health tech startups. Shri. Robin Alex Panicker, Chief Product Officer at Finotes, discussed strategies for product development and scaling. Smt. Tina James, CEO of Revyrie Global, focused on global expansion, while Shri. Krishnan RV Iyer, Co-founder & CEO of Waybeo, highlighted resilience and adaptability in entrepreneurship.

FOUNDERS MEET 24.0

CALICUT EDITION

BY FOUNDERS
AND EQUIPMENTS

KERALA
STARTUP MISSION

OCTOBER
18
2024



Building on the momentum, the 24th edition in Calicut continued the spirit of collaboration by attracting a strong network of founders, industry experts, and key stakeholders. Both editions provided an exceptional platform for learning and networking, further supporting Kerala's vibrant startup ecosystem.

KERALA
STARTUP MISSION

GOOGLE FOR STARTUPS AI ACADEMY INDIA - 2024

The excitement is in full swing here in Kochi as early-stage startups from across the region come together to drive impactful AI solutions in Healthcare, Climate, Agriculture, Education, Financial Inclusion, Cybersecurity, and Public Infrastructure.

With inspiring workshops, hands-on mentorship, and exclusive access to Google resources—including up to \$350K in cloud credits—these innovators are taking big steps toward building human-centered AI for India's future.



WOMEN ENTREPRENEUR OF THE MONTH

PHONOLOGIX

PIONEERING ACCESSIBLE SPEECH THERAPY FOR CHILDREN

Phonologix is transforming speech therapy for children with communication disorders through its innovative platform, Speech Ally. Founded by Elizabeth Thomas, a seasoned Speech-Language Pathologist with 23 years of

experience, Phonologix addresses the critical need for accessible therapy. The platform offers a combination of e-learning modules and teletherapy sessions, empowering parents to become active participants in their child's therapy. With over 30,000 sessions conducted across 10 countries, Phonologix has impacted 3,100+ children. Its mission is to bridge the gap in speech therapy access, especially in underserved regions like India and the Middle East.

Children with disorders such as autism, hearing impairments, or speech impediments face social isolation and bullying, hindering their growth. The shortage of certified Speech-Language Pathologists (SLPs) in countries like India further exacerbates the issue. With an SLP-to-child ratio of 1:4000 in India (compared to 1:30 in the U.S.), many families struggle to access consistent, high-quality therapy services, especially in Tier 2 and 3 cities. Delayed or inadequate intervention leads to long-term challenges, including poor academic performance and social exclusion.

Phonologix provides a revolutionary approach to early intervention through its platform, Speech Ally. Designed for children aged 1½ and above, Speech Ally combines gamified learning activities with one-on-one teletherapy sessions



to ensure comprehensive support. By offering customized dashboards, multilingual content, and a vast goal bank, Speech Ally enables parents and facilitators to practice therapeutic exercises at home, leading to faster progress.

For therapy centers and schools, the platform streamlines clinical operations, offering machine-learning tools that automate activity selection and increase therapist productivity. Its goal bank and documentation tools ensure that therapy centers can deliver more efficient services while tracking each child's progress in real time.

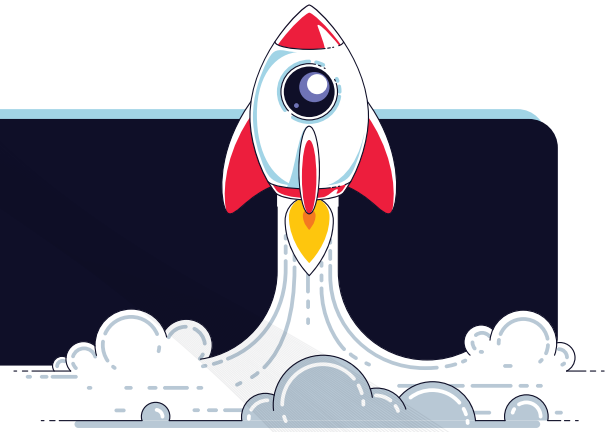
Since its launch in 2020, Phonologix has conducted more than 30,000 teletherapy sessions in seven Indian languages, helping over 3,100 children. The platform is used across 64 cities and towns in India and several other countries. Phonologix has signed partnerships with therapy centers in the UAE and has begun working on CSR projects, such as a collaboration with Bajaj-Finserv in Pune. Phonologix's mission is to help 20,000 children communicate better by 2027.

Phonologix has garnered multiple awards, including the NCPEDP-MPHASIS Universal Design Award (2022), Editor's Choice Social Entrepreneur of the Year by Jagran New Media's Her Zindagi (2023), and the Visa She's Next Program (2023). Incubated at NSRCEL, IIM Bangalore, and DERBI Foundation, the company is poised for further growth as it opens up new partnerships and expands its services.

With a dedicated 18-member team, Phonologix is driving a vision of inclusivity, ensuring that children, regardless of their location, have access to world-class speech therapy services, helping them reach their full potential.

What's **NEW?**

STARTUP ECOSYSTEM TRENDS



As we move further into 2024, the startup landscape is becoming a dynamic field shaped by a blend of technological advancements, economic influences, and a strong focus on sustainability. Global events, market demands, and evolving consumer expectations are crafting a new era for startups, with sectors like artificial intelligence, climate technology, fintech, and digital commerce taking center stage. Let's explore some of the most prominent startup trends defining 2024.

Mergers & Acquisitions: Strategic Growth on the Rise

The M&A landscape has undergone a major transformation, spurred by the pandemic and economic fluctuations. Post-pandemic, we saw a surge in mergers fueled by low interest rates and abundant capital. However, in 2023, rising inflation and interest rates began to affect valuations and deal volumes. Nevertheless, technology, healthcare, and sustainability sectors remain resilient and continue to drive M&A trends for 2024. These industries are central to strategic growth, offering fertile ground for startups aiming to enhance their reach and capabilities through acquisitions.

Tech and AI firms have become a focal point for M&A activity. Companies such as Replit and Device42 illustrate the growing interest in AI-powered solutions, with industry giants acquiring these startups to enhance their AI capabilities. The acquisition of Device42 by Freshworks and Reliance Jio's JioBrain initiative further underscore the trend, showcasing how India is also emerging as a crucial player in this space. For businesses, the pursuit of AI and technology expertise through M&A is a key tactic for maintaining competitive advantage.

AI Matures and Climate Tech Gains Momentum

Artificial intelligence has progressed from a buzzword to a critical tool driving business growth. Investments in AI reached an unprecedented \$550 billion in 2023, and the focus in 2024 has shifted to practical, ROI-driven applications. Investors are now prioritizing tangible applications like AI-powered healthcare diagnostics, predictive maintenance, and hyper-personalized customer experiences. The focus on real-world AI applications signals a shift toward substance over hype, with businesses seeking measurable value in their tech

investments.

Simultaneously, climate tech is experiencing record-breaking investments, with a 56% growth from 2022 to 2023. In response to the climate crisis, cleantech startups are pioneering renewable energy, carbon capture, and sustainable agricultural solutions. These innovations are not only crucial for environmental preservation but also represent substantial opportunities for investors looking to support the green revolution.

Cross-Border M&A: Global Expansion in a Connected World

Cross-border mergers and acquisitions have accelerated, with U.S. and Indian companies leading the charge. Indian firms are increasingly exploring international opportunities, illustrated by Bharti Airtel's significant investment in BT Group and Mankind Pharma's acquisition of Bharat Serums. This growing interest in cross-border partnerships reflects an ambition for market diversification and global expansion. The trend underscores a shared objective: to extend market reach and navigate complex international landscapes.



Fintech Expands Beyond Payments

In fintech, digital payments have become the standard, but startups are now shifting their focus to areas like digital wealth management, financial inclusion, and blockchain-enabled solutions. U.S.-based companies, such as Robinhood and Stripe, continue to lead in this field with strategic acquisitions to enhance their offerings for Gen Z and beyond. In India, however, fintech firms are preparing for IPOs and focusing on organic growth, especially in AI-driven advisory services and UPI-based solutions. By 2025, the Indian fintech market is expected to reach \$150 billion, underscoring the sector's immense potential.

Emphasis on ESG and Sustainability

Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) factors are increasingly influencing M&A strategies, as businesses aim to meet growing consumer demands for ethical and sustainable practices. In the U.S., companies like Charm Industrial are capturing the attention of buyers focused on carbon capture and sustainability. Meanwhile, in India, there is a surge of M&A activity in the energy sector, driven by ambitious renewable energy targets. Recent investments, like IvyCap Ventures' funding for SolarSquare, showcase the rising commitment to ESG-friendly initiatives that support a cleaner, greener future.

Decentralization and Web3 Adoption

Decentralization is steadily gaining traction. With a 126% increase in venture capital for blockchain and Web3 in 2023, there is widespread interest in DeFi, DAOs, and the burgeoning metaverse. As Web3 concepts become mainstream, the possibilities of a decentralized future are starting to resonate across various industries, from finance to media. Blockchain startups focusing on DeFi applications, NFTs, and DAOs are well-positioned to drive this shift towards a new era of digital autonomy.

The Future of Work and Mental Health

The startup ecosystem has been quick to respond to the evolving work environment post-pandemic. Remote and hybrid work arrangements have created opportunities for startups specializing in virtual collaboration, talent management, and employee wellness. Meanwhile, mental health tech is evolving

beyond meditation apps, with innovative solutions that offer personalized therapy and AI-powered assessments. These offerings are reshaping the modern workplace, catering to the needs of a diverse and distributed workforce.

E-commerce: The Rise of Hyper-Personalization

As e-commerce becomes more competitive, startups focusing on hyper-personalization are gaining an edge. From AI-driven recommendations to immersive shopping experiences, consumers expect tailored interactions that go beyond traditional online shopping. Startups providing bespoke product suggestions, dynamic pricing, and augmented reality try-ons are transforming the e-commerce space by creating meaningful and memorable experiences for users.

The Creator Economy: Enabling Digital Entrepreneurs



Influencers are increasingly leading the charge in the creator economy, with platforms that facilitate content creation and monetization growing in demand. This booming sector is opening up new avenues for startups that empower creators to build sustainable businesses. Tools for content creation, community building, and direct fan engagement are driving the growth of a creator-centric ecosystem, allowing digital entrepreneurs to connect deeply with their audiences.

Navigating Regulatory Challenges

The regulatory landscape has always been a critical factor in the startup world, and 2024 is no exception. While U.S. antitrust enforcement has softened, India is tightening scrutiny on data privacy and foreign investment. With the Indian government's "Make in India" initiative and increased focus on data sovereignty, sectors like

telecom and technology face more rigorous evaluation. This regulatory environment presents both opportunities and challenges, emphasizing the importance of strategic navigation for startups seeking growth.

GOVERNMENT AS A MARKETPLACE

GAAM

To get an early adopter for a startup product or solution is challenging and the Government of Kerala addresses these issues by becoming an early adopter for the startups as envisaged in the Kerala Startup Policy 2017. Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) has emerged as a transformative force for startups by facilitating access to government procurement through its "Government as a Marketplace" (GAAM) initiative. This unique program allows government bodies to directly procure innovative products and services from startups without the typical tendering process. By doing so, KSUM has not only boosted the visibility and growth of startups but also enabled government agencies to access cutting-edge technologies that improve public services and administrative efficiency.

Empowering Startups Through Direct Government Procurement

One of the standout features of the GAAM initiative is the streamlined approach it offers to startups seeking to work with government departments. Unlike traditional procurement models that require lengthy tendering processes, the "Government as a Marketplace" program operates under the Kerala State IT Policy, allowing government agencies to purchase directly from startups. With a financial ceiling of ₹50 lakhs, this initiative is accessible to a wide range of emerging businesses, helping them to scale and expand while maintaining a direct line of communication with government clients. Similarly Kerala Startup Mission also facilitates limited tenders, limited to startups registered with Kerala Startup Mission upto a purchase price of Rs 300 Lakhs.

Through KSUM's Demand Day and Demo Day programs, startups are able to present their solutions directly to government officials. These programs function as platforms where startups showcase their innovations, ranging from IT solutions to advanced technologies like AI, IoT, and blockchain. These events are crucial for helping both startups and government departments identify potential collaborations and specific needs that startups can address through their offerings.

Innovation in Public Services

The "Government as a Marketplace" initiative does more than just provide business opportunities for startups; it drives public sector innovation. With access to a wide range of homegrown tech solutions, government departments can implement tools that streamline their processes, enhance public services, and foster administrative efficiency. This collaboration benefits both the public sector and the startup ecosystem by solving real-world challenges and improving service delivery across sectors such as health, education, infrastructure, and governance.

IMPACT

Several startups that have participated in the GAM initiative have already seen significant success. These companies have introduced their innovations to government bodies in areas such as e-governance, environmental sustainability, and smart city solutions. The

value of these collaborations is immense, as government agencies gain access to the latest in technology, while startups obtain invaluable business opportunities and the ability to scale.

KSUM's initiative has also fostered a culture of collaboration where startups can co-create solutions with government departments, further amplifying the impact of their innovations. This reciprocal relationship enhances the functionality and effectiveness of government services while offering startups the opportunity to grow alongside their public sector partners.

KSRTC - Courier Service
Lunch Bell - Kudumbashree
Kerala State Financial Enterprises - Power App
High Flow Nasal Oxygen Therapy Machine
Development of Financial Fraud Complaint
Tracking System - Kerala Police

Total 272 Projects
Value : 29.07 Crores

The Mechanisms

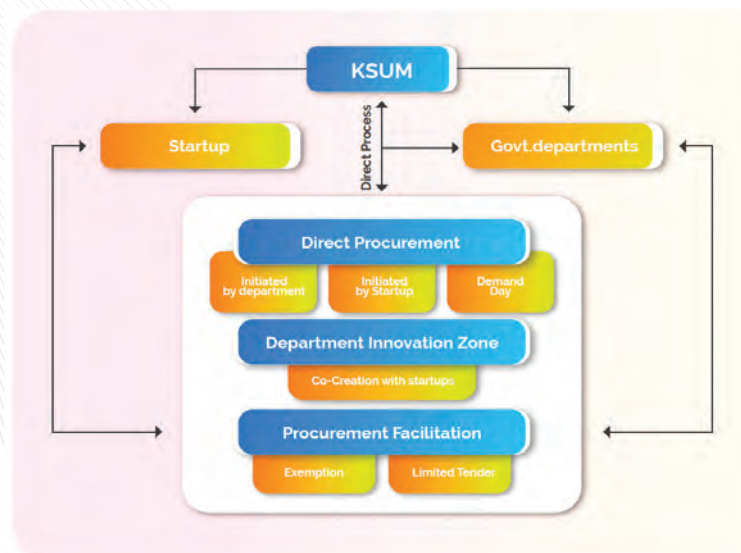
Kerala Startup Mission is approached by various Government Departments for the development of various solutions (hardware/software) based on the requirements arising within the department. These requests are met through a facilitation devised by KSUM.

Kerala Startup Mission facilitate the entire process by helping departments to identify a startup capable of development of the requirements. This is done through a limited EOI being called among startups that are registered with KSUM. Recently, Government of Kerala recently announced that Government Departments, Public Sector Undertakings, Autonomous Bodies, Boards, Corporations, Local Self Government institutions etc shall call for a limited tender among the startups registered with KSUM for design, development and implementation of projects upto Rs 3 Crore vide order G.O.(Rt)No.2/2022/SPD dt 05.07.2022

Objective: To help the Government Department to identify a startup capable of providing a required solution.

Process

- Government department to freeze the requirement.
- The requirement to be shared with KSUM as per the template.
- The EOI on approval by KSUM will be circulated among the startups registered
- Startups after submission of EOI will be called in for an interaction with Department representatives.
- This is followed by Submission of Technical Proposal.
- The startups who submit the technical proposal are then invited for a presentation before a Technical committee comprising of members from the respective department, KSUM and KSITM.
- Startups who qualify the technical evaluation are then asked to submit the financial proposal.
- Rank 1 among the startups is identified by the method of Quality and Cost Based Selection (QCBS) wherein 70% marks for the technical proposal and 30% for the financial proposal.
- The Rank 1 startup is then recommended to the Department.
- The payment is made directly by the department to the startup after signing an agreement as mentioned in G.O (Ms) No 19/2017/ITD dt 04.08.2017



VISIT THE WEBSITE FOR MORE INFO

<https://gm.startupmission.in/>



STARTUP SCHEMES

SCHEMES FOR STARTUPS TO BUILD AND SCALE UP

There are quite a few schemes which can be leveraged by startups to build and scale up their ventures. Some of these are offered by multinational giants while there is a pioneering innovation grants programme launched by the Government of Kerala. Following is a snapshot of some of the schemes:

PATENT REIMBURSEMENT

Kerala Government, through Kerala Startup Mission has launched a scheme called Patent Support Scheme, where support is provided for startups and student entrepreneurs who are able to secure a patent.

Patent Support System intends to support startup entrepreneurs and student entrepreneurs by reimbursing the patent cost including consultation fee, subject to a limit of Rs. 2 lakh per Indian patent awarded. For awarded foreign patents on a single subject matter, up to Rs. 10 lakh would be reimbursed. The reimbursement will be done in 3 stages during filing, prosecution and award.



178

APPLICATIONS

134

PATENTS REIMBURSED

1.43 CR

FUND RELEASED

ELIGIBILITY

- The patent applications which are filed only after 09.11.2015 will be considered.
- The patent support can be directly applied by Student Entrepreneurs through their IEDC's.
- For a startup, it should be a legal entity registered with RoC as Pvt Ltd or LLP. The schemes are not applicable to Innovators.
- The startup must be registered in Kerala, within 10 years from date of Incorporation and must have a DIPP and Udyog Aadhar.
- For students, the support will be given only for those who are pursuing the academics.
- The scheme does not extend support to patent renewals and prosecutions against appellate authority who have already rejected one's patent claims.

BENEFITS

- Rs.2 Lakhs/ Indian Patent
- Rs.10 Lakhs/International Patent
- Activity Covered are: Provisional Patents Filings, Patent Search, Drafting, Filings, Claims Preparations, Fast tracking Fees, Claims prosecutions, Granting
- Activities of Prosecution against Appellate Authorities who have already rejected your claims due to Valid reasons and Patent renewals are not covered.
- The scheme supports only patents, not trademarks, copyrights or any other Intellectual Property Rights



TECHNOLOGY TRANSFER & COMMERCIALIZATION SUPPORT SCHEME

Kerala Government, through Kerala Startup Mission has launched a scheme called Technology Transfer Scheme, startups who have purchased or sourced Technology License from any Government research Institution in India and are working on it to develop as a commercializable product. This scheme intends to support Technology License/Transfer Startups by providing a funding support of maximum of Rs.10 Lakhs in the form of reimbursement for the startups, who have paid to the Research Institution. However, the support is limited to 90% of the technology fee to be paid to the Research entity.

The terms & conditions for the benefits under the scheme will be as follows:

- The license/technology purchased through this scheme shall be owned by the Startup or as per the terms specified by the research agency.
- Kerala Startup Mission shall be given 2% royalty for the product being commercialized, which shall be limited to the amount supported by the Kerala Startup Mission under the scheme.
- The Startup is expected to commercialize the product for which the license /technology is purchased within a period of 2 years.
- In case, the Startup is unable to commercialize the product within two years, then the startup will be liable to repay the contribution given by the Kerala Startup Mission.
- The Startup will sign an agreement with the Kerala startup Mission before availing the benefit.

PROCESS OF SCHEME

- STEP 1 : Online Application
- STEP 2 : Document Submissions in hardcopies
- STEP 3 : Processing
- STEP 4 : Fund Release to Startup



ELIGIBILITY CRITERIA

- The startup should be a registered company in Kerala as an LLP or Pvt. Ltd company and should have an active registration with KSUM at the time of application.
- The startup company has DIPP registration and an 'Active'/ 'Active Compliant' status with MCA.
- The startups shall not have any other pending dues with any of the Government agencies, KSUM, Other incubators in the state and shall not be blacklisted by any Govt. agency in India

BENEFITS

- Technology License / Transfer support for Startups will be a maximum of Rs.10 Lakhs. However, the support is limited to 90% of the technology fee to be paid to the Research entity.

DOCUMENT CHECKLIST

- Original hard copy of Invoice & Receipt with authorized seal and signature from the research organization.
- Original Bank Statement showing amount transferred (Verified by Bank Manager).
- Technology Transfer Agreement with research organization. Residence Proof details of the director(s)/ applicant(s).
- Company incorporation documents (Incorporation Certificates, MoA, AoA, DIN nos).
- Undertaking that the startup has not so far claimed and will not claim any sort of reimbursement costs from any other organizations/ govt. bodies and if found, they will pay twice the amount to KSUM, that is reimbursed through Technology support scheme.
- Canceled Cheque of the company and Bank details (Branch name, IFSC Code).

STARTUP DPIIT RECOGNITION APPLICATION ON NATIONAL SINGLE WINDOW SYSTEM

उद्योग संवर्धन और आंतरिक व्यापार विभाग
DEPARTMENT FOR PROMOTION OF INDUSTRY AND INTERNAL TRADE

INVEST INDIA
PROMOTING INVESTMENT IN INDIA

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National Single Window System

CENTRAL APPROVALS
Issued by Ministries of Govt. of India

STATE APPROVALS
Issued by States of Govt. of India

GOVERNMENT SCHEMES
Avail the benefits by Govt. of India

LOGIN

Access over **610 Central Approvals** and **3879 State Approvals**

Explore, Apply and Get all the approvals required to start your business in India

Central Approvals Search Approvals EXPLORE ALL

Don't know which approvals are required? [Click Here & Know Your Approvals](#)

"We are laying a red carpet for all global companies to come and establish their presence in India. Very few countries will offer the kind of opportunities India does today."
Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi

BENEFITS

How does NSWS help you?

The National Single Window System (NSWS) is a digital platform to guide you in identifying and applying for approvals according to your business requirements. The Know Your Approvals (KYA) module includes guidance for 32 Central Departments and 32 States. You are advised to check the relevant Government portals for any other required approvals. The portal hosts applications for approvals from 28 Central Departments and 20 State Governments. These approvals can be applied through NSWS.

PLAY VIDEO TO KNOW MORE

All approvals in one place
Get everything you need in one place without having to go to individual Ministries, Departments or States

Real-time status tracking
Get real-time updates on the status of your applications and plan your next steps with ease

Secure document repository
Upload documents once and use them in all your applications

Easy renewal
Renew your approvals easily through a seamless interface

Fast query management
Get quick resolution to your queries from our dedicated team

Know your approvals
Use the intelligent questionnaire to easily find out which approvals you might need for your business

Connect with us from 3pm to 4pm, Monday- Friday for grievance/query redressal. Hear directly from National Single Window System technical team. [Click here to connect](#)

REGISTRATION AS A STARTUP

www.nsws.gov.in

FILL THE APPLICATION FORM

Click on > Apply Now > Common Registration Form > Startup Recognition by DPIIT

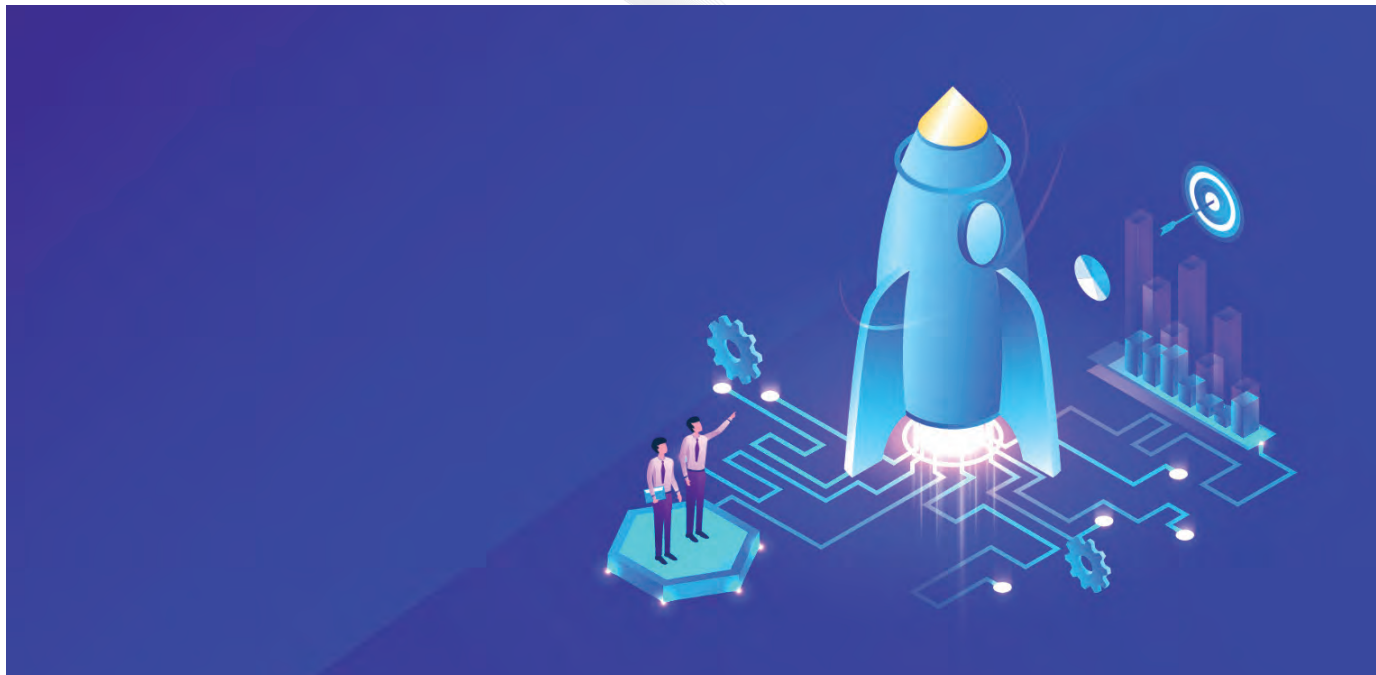
REGISTER ON STARTUP INDIA

www.startupindia.gov.in

DOWNLOAD THE CERTIFICATE

www.nsws.gov.in / www.startupindia.gov.in

KSUM UNIQUE ID REGISTRATION



■ FOR REGISTRATION

Visit www.startups.startupmission.in and click on the 'GET YOUR UNIQUE ID HERE' button.

■ APPLICATION FORM

Use your Startup India Credentials (credentials used to generate your DIPP Certificate)

■ REGISTRATION PROCESS

After login you will be redirected to the Unique ID application form. Fill in the required details and click the Submit button.

■ ID APPROVAL

After registration is successful it will take a maximum of three days for the approval by KSUM.

■ CERTIFICATE FROM KSUM

Companies should generate a certificate from their profile page to complete the registration process.

■ VERIFICATION OF DETAILS

Once the certificate is generated, Companies should visit www.startups.startupmission.in/web/certified_startups and search with their 'company' name to check whether the company is listed here.

Kerala has around 6200+ startups working in various sectors spread across its 14 districts. Our startups work in wide range of sectors including Artificial Intelligence, Hardware, Healthcare, Fin tech, Bio Technology etc.

Have a thought, comment or suggestion to share with us?

We'd love to hear from you.
Write to us at



info@startupmission.com



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